

Historical, Cadastral, & Cultural Overview of the Ghost Town of Van Houten, Colfax Co., N.M.

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Abstract—Van Houten, located in Colfax County, New Mexico, was once a thriving coal mining village established as the Willow Mining Camp in 1902. A true American melting pot, it was built by immigrants from diverse backgrounds, including Dutch, Germans, Austrians, Italians, Montenegrins, Greeks, and African Americans. The town was renamed in honor of Jan van Houten /jan van 'hau.tən/, who revitalized the struggling camp and saved it from economic collapse.

Van Houten flourished until 1954 (1500-2000 residents at its peak in 1915), when the post-war decline in coal demand and the rise of alternative energy sources led to its abandonment. In the 1960s, most of the town's structures were demolished due to changing tax codes. Today, the remnants of the tippie, mule barn, and a few standing houses serve as enduring reminders of the town's rich history and cultural heritage.

Index Terms—Van Houten, Willow Coal Camp, Jan van Houten, Coal, Mining, Raton, Colfax, Maxwell Land Grant, New Mexico, GIS, Archaeology, History

I. INTRODUCTION

Ghost towns are a frequently overlooked historical richness, and while Van Houten greatly benefits from the amount of curation by the NRA Whittington Center, an authoritative document encompassing all aspects of the town has not yet been created.

This paper presents our combined research efforts into the historical, cartographic, and cultural aspects of Van Houten. This was achieved through many avenues of research, including exploration, surveying, GIS analysis, historical, genealogical, and the compilation of existing documentation. Our novel contributions to the archaeological preservation of Van Houten include:

- Synthesis of much published information and oral histories.
- Discovery of unrecorded foundations and key points through exploration.
- Extensive cadastral surveying and cartographic creation along with novel GIS integrations to make a comprehensive Ephemeral Recency Map (most recent structures depicted).
- Cultural preservation through the compilation of stories.
- ...

Our goal is to provide a brief and pertinent overview of significant dates, events, and locations to familiarize a new researcher

with the essential information about Van Houten, and to give them an idea of what life may have been like. This research, while not comprehensive, aims to provide a foundation for further research by clarifying essential information. It is our intent that this brief overview will provide readers with a base knowledge of the Van Houten mine camp, and be an inspiration for further research.

II. RELATED WORK

Much of the work done concerning Van Houten (VH) has been done in two camps. Some researchers are interested in the technical aspects of the mining operations and their remnants, whereas others are focused on the cultural aspect of the town, depending on their primary audiences.

A. Cultural Sources

The authoritative authors and repositories on the culture of VH are the counselors of the NRA Whittington Center Adventure Camp, Kenneth Fordyce (and Alice Bullock by proxy), Judo Yaksich, certain ghost town histories, and the Raton Museum's collections.

Reading the stories of the residents of VH makes them come to life once again, and when walking through the scrub-oak covered hills, one feels as though they are among them once again.

B. Technical Sources

Several surveys have been conducted on the remnants of the blasted openings to the VH mines, and are quite thorough in their description of the inner workings of the mines. Additionally, old company maps of the internal workings of the mines may provide further historical context to the dangerous working conditions of the miners. The best sources for this genre of research have been H.B. Nickelson's report [6], The Archaeological Survey of Mine Lands [8], and the aforementioned internal maps.

By pairing these resources with some older general area maps, relief shading maps, satellite maps, and exploration, one can begin to grasp the way that the mines operated and their impact on the landscape today.

III. TIMELINE

In order to understand the passage of time in relation to events that have occurred in VH, a timeline has been compiled. Much of the information in the timeline comes from the Whittington Center (WC) documents [1]. Additional sources include other publications and newspaper articles, as well as certain technical reports that include historical data. Our comprehensive timeline is depicted in table 1.

TABLE I
VAN HOUTEN TIMELINE

Year	Month	Events
1902	Dec.	Willow Post office established. J. van Houten and Company form the St. Louis, Rocky Mountain & Pacific Company.
1903		Willow mining camp firmly established.
1904		Van Houten (VH) harassed by strikes. 18 scabs.
1906		279 Miners underground; 20 Men outside; 5 boys underground; 4 boys outside. Willow Mining Camp renamed to VH.
1907*		St. Louis, Rocky Mountain & Pacific Co. take control of the mines.
1910		Atchison, Topeka, & Santa Fe Railroad extends branch line to VH. Population of 611.
1915		Peak VH Population of 1500-2000
1920		Clubhouse opened
1934		VH is unionized under UMWA (United Mine Workers of America).
1938		Jan van Houten predicts decline of VH.
1940		VH Mines temporarily closed.
1941		VH Mines reopened due to wartime coal demand.
1948		24 Day Coal Strike.
1949	May	Only 8-10 families remaining.
1952		Post office closes
1954	Feb. May	VH Mine closure announced. VH Mines close, left on standby.
1955		Kaiser Steel Corporation purchased the property.
1960*		Kaiser Steel Company demolishes standing buildings for tax reasons.
1973		Land traded for NRA site.
1979		Surveys conducted by H. B. Nickelson.
1986		Surveys conducted by Y. R. Oakes
1987		Van Houten Mine Fire Fencing Project
1988		Van Houten Mine Closure Project
1989		Van Houten Reclamation Project Van Houten Mine Fire Fence Maintenance Project
1990		Van Houten Mine Waste Hauling Project

IV. CULTURE

Van Houten displays a remarkable richness of character that may be more evident to us for having lived in its skeleton. It is the cultural elements that make VH *

A. Pertaining to the Communes

The ww1 stories The known burials are detailed in table 2.

B. From the Old Country

Feuds/murder stories, rakia,

TABLE II
KNOWN GRAVES IN VH

Name	Coordinates
Carmelita Valdez	(36.78637, -104.56178)
Unknown (White Stone)	(36.78644, -104.56172)
Unknown (Cross)	(36.78636, -104.56169)
Unknown (Engraved Rectangle)	(36.78635, -104.56167)
Nestor Luder	(36.79332, -104.56950)

C. The Devil's Kitchen

Near the town of VH, there is a naturally occurring eternal flame. The present location has been lost, but multiple old residents from the town have attested to its existence. It is fueled by natural methane gas seepage and has been the center of several legends.

It is said that it was close enough to VH, and that on pleasant days, all the families and schoolchildren would go to the Devil's Kitchen to picnic. It may be from this that the nearby "Ghost Hill" gets its name, for the children would play there as their parents picnicked.

Stories tell of an old pioneer who was being pursued by indians, and upon firing his musket hit an area near the Devil's Kitchen, which erupted into flames. The indians, thinking that the great spirits were protecting the pioneer, left him in peace.

D. Myths

Myths concerning the town of Van Houten have largely been sourced from counselor stories and regional campfire tales. Although these stories are not directly related to the history of mines and surrounding town, we feel they are an aspect of Van Houten that many researchers may find value in.

V. TOWN LAYOUT AND GEOGRAPHY

Due to the fact that many of the town's residents self-segregated into cultural groups (due to language barriers), we started our town related cultural research by grouping Van Houten into various "Sub-Communes" to better track the diverse populations of Van Houten. These communes are named based on significant standing structures in the areas, historical residents, or other geographic elements that make them noteworthy.

In a similar manner, we also sectioned off various parcels of land in the GIS software to account for the industrial mining regions, each of which is named after the contemporary mine name that was used in their time. These borders are defined with respect to the underground shafts that they contain, and are drawn in accordance with today's best knowledge of their precise placements.

A. Methodology for Foundation Mapping

Faithfully reconstructing the layout of Van Houten's residential structures proved difficult due to the need to pick a certain reference timeframe. Van Houten was built over itself in some areas (most notably Monte Hill). This layering made it hard to determine which foundations should be depicted on a map, as newer structures intersect or replace older ones.

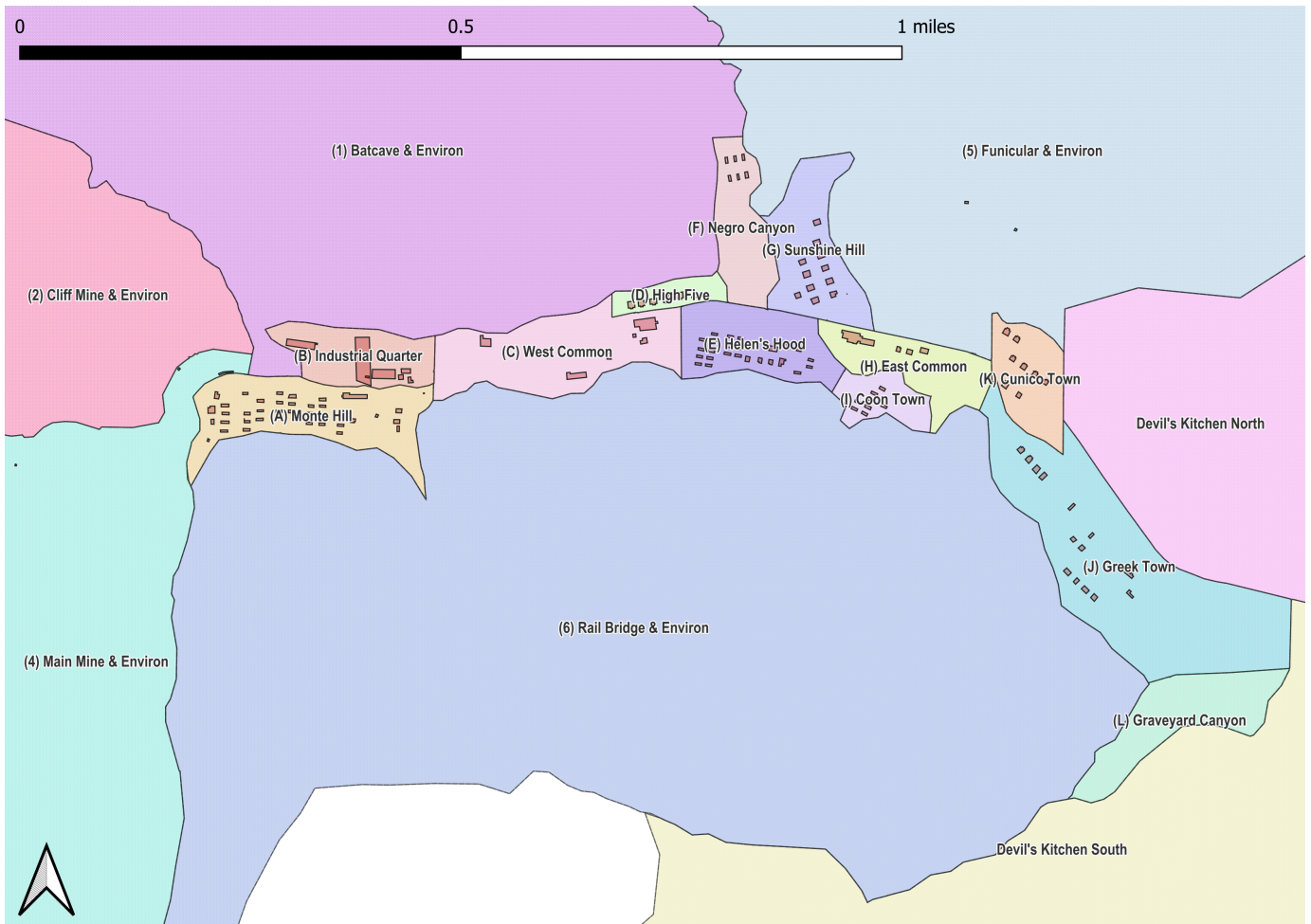


Fig. 1. Regional Sectional Map.

To create a comprehensive and intelligible map, each foundation had to meet a set of criteria:

- 1) All foundations with known visible, physical remnants were mapped.
- 2) For foundations no longer visible:
 - a) The most recent known structure at a given spot took precedence, effectively overwriting any earlier buildings it replaced or covered.
 - b) Inclusion on the map required some form of physical or corroborative evidence that was consistent and detailed enough to confidently approximate the structure's shape and position onto a satellite base map. This evidence included appearance on historical mine maps, depressions on shaded relief imagery, satellite data, artifact scatter, road alignment, or triangulation via known positions in period photographs.

This created a highly useful map that shows a researcher or explorer the most recent structure at any given location. While the buildings may not have all existed at the same time, they represent what was last present, and thus what would still be

found regarding debris, ruins, or artifacts today.

B. Methodology for Mine Mapping

Mine mapping was far easier than foundational mapping, for there exist internal mine maps that were drawn with high accuracy. Additionally, the surveys presented in [6] [8] provide modern data relevant in locating the historic adits. On top of this, significant exploration has found other adits. Knowledge of adit locations was pieced together with bigger picture mine schemes to create the overlay displayed on the map. This novel map style has been named an "Ephemeral Recency Map" (ERM).

VI. FUTURE RESEARCH

It may be of great benefit that the most active researchers of Van Houten (that is to say, the counselors of the NRA Whittington Center Adventure Camp) "adopt" a certain commune or mine section and conduct in depth research on their subsection. This would divide up the work in research significantly, and allow one to become an expert on a certain commune, getting highly in depth and not having to do significant research on all the other communes. This would

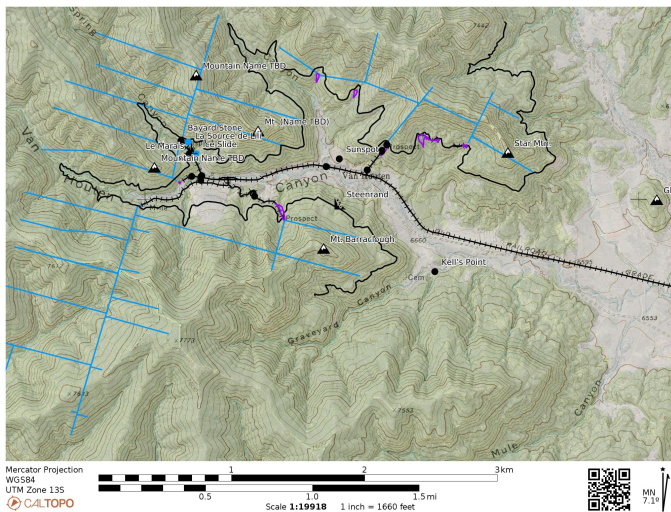


Fig. 2. Rail & Mine Map.

promote a great depth of research and could be implemented either formally or informally.

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